Journal of
Media, Culture & Society

Techno-Humanitarianism as Technocolonial Practice: The Accountability Paradox

Journal:	*Media Culture and Society*
Manuscript ID	Draft
Manuscript Type:	Main Article
Keyword:	techno-humanitarianism, technocolonialism, humanitarian communication, governance, humanitarian emergency, humanitarian crisis
Abstract:	Big Tech is increasingly deployed in humanitarian crises in the Global South, framing technological intervention as an act of care. This article examines techno-humanitarianism as the discourse through which technocolonial governance is constituted as care. It asks through what communicative mechanisms this constitution operates, and what subject positions it produces. Through qualitative case study analysis of thirteen interventions across five technologically mediated modes, the article develops the discourse-enablement thesis. It demonstrates that techno-humanitarianism functions as the legitimating grammar of technocolonial practice. The grammar of inverse empowerment demonstrates that humanitarian language discursively constitutes conditions of dependency as forms of access and empowerment. Crisis conditions in the Global South function as testing grounds for technologies that would face regulatory constraint in non-crisis contexts. The constitutive accountability paradox identifies how the conditions generating techno-humanitarian authority are structurally incompatible with the conditions enabling accountability. The article concludes that the accountability deficit is structural rather than correctable, because the conditions that generate techno-humanitarian authority, speed of deployment and operational scale, bypass the institutional processes through which accountability is produced.

SCHOLARONE™
Manuscripts

Techno-Humanitarianism as Technocolonial Practice: The Accountability Paradox

Abstract

Big Tech is increasingly deployed in humanitarian crises in the Global South, framing technological intervention as an act of care.

This article examines techno-humanitarianism as the discourse through which technocolonial governance is constituted as care. It asks through what communicative mechanisms this constitution operates, and what subject positions it produces. Through qualitative case study analysis of thirteen interventions across five technologically mediated modes, the article develops the discourse-enablement thesis. It demonstrates that techno-humanitarianism functions as the legitimating grammar of technocolonial practice.

The grammar of inverse empowerment demonstrates that humanitarian language discursively constitutes conditions of dependency as forms of access and empowerment.

MCS for Review

Crisis conditions in the Global South function as testing grounds for technologies that would face regulatory constraint in non-crisis contexts. The constitutive accountability paradox identifies how the conditions generating techno-humanitarian authority are structurally incompatible with the conditions enabling accountability.

The article concludes that the accountability deficit is structural rather than correctable, because the conditions that generate techno-humanitarian authority, speed of deployment and operational scale, bypass the institutional processes through which accountability is produced.

Keywords: techno-humanitarianism, corporate humanitarian communication, constitutive communication, field theory, accountability, technocolonialism

MCS for Review

1. Introduction

In March 2022, Airbnb activated its global host network to provide free temporary accommodation to Ukrainian refugees. Within weeks, the platform had housed over 100,000 displaced people, outpacing the operational response of several established humanitarian organisations. The company's communicative framing positioned Airbnb as enabling hosts to respond at a speed and scale that traditional humanitarian architecture could not match. Yet the populations housed through the platform were not addressed as refugees with rights under international protection law. They were service users, governed by the platform's terms and conditions, dependent on the willingness of individual hosts in a marketplace. The platform performed a humanitarian function without producing the humanitarian subject that function presupposes.

At the other end of the institutional spectrum, Palantir Technologies has provided data analytics services to the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees since 2016, processing the personal data of displaced communities for needs assessment and population management. The partnership is framed as data-driven care in the service of protection. Yet the communities whose data these systems process are reduced to data subjects within frameworks that foreclose meaningful consent. In humanitarian settings, as Madianou (2025, p. 81) argues, consent operates not as a

MCS for Review

safeguard but as a mechanism that "normalizes and legitimates a system of dependency, control, and coloniality."

These two cases occupy opposite ends of a phenomenon this article examines. One is situational and highly visible. The other is institutional and largely invisible to publics. Both involve the communicative constitution of corporate technology as humanitarian, not as cause-related marketing but as instances in which corporate organisations deploy core technological capacities in direct response to humanitarian need, claiming authority over crisis-affected communities that existing accountability frameworks were not designed to evaluate.

Existing theoretical frameworks address dimensions of this phenomenon but none accounts for it adequately. The post-humanitarian framework diagnosed a structural transformation in humanitarian appeals, tracing a departure from solidarity-based engagement toward what Chouliaraki (2013, p. 2) describes as a blurring of the boundary between the public logic of economic utilitarianism and "the private logic of sentimental obligation towards vulnerable others." That framework identified how INGOs depoliticised solidarity into consumer-oriented moral performance, with the ironic spectator engaging in low-effort acts of identification that sustain the donor's cosmopolitan self-image. But the analysis was developed to explain humanitarian organisations internalising market logic, not corporate actors assuming operational humanitarian functions. The phenomenon examined here carries the trajectory post-

MCS Prior Review

humanitarianism identified to its logical endpoint, because corporate technology now occupies the operational space that INGOs once held.

The concept of technocolonialism advances the analysis by identifying how digital humanitarian technologies function simultaneously as interventions and as mechanisms that naturalise technocratic power. The convergence thesis, as Madianou (2019, p. 1) formulates it, traces how "colonial, commercial and humanitarian interests" come together within digital innovation, demonstrating that humanitarian data practices reinscribe longstanding asymmetries between intervening institutions and the communities subjected to their operations. The "colonial matrix of power" (Mignolo, 2011, pp. xv–xvi) provides a broader frame, mapping how Western-hegemonic systems of knowledge extract value while erasing the epistemic agency of those governed. Yet the technocolonial framework does not specify the communicative mechanisms through which extractive logic is legitimated as care, or explain how corporate technology comes to be legible as humanitarian in the first place.

A related body of work examines how the framing of lives determines their political standing. The concept of grievability establishes that social and political "frames" determine which lives are recognised as fully human and which remain, in Butler's (2009, p. 2) formulation, "ungrievable." If humanitarian communication produces crisis-affected communities as users, data subjects, or financial agents rather than as rights-bearing persons, the framing itself determines the scope of political

MCS Prior Review

recognition available to them. The structural silencing of those subjected to governance by those who govern (Spivak, 1988, p. 171) applies with particular force to technologically mediated interventions, where the terms of engagement are encoded in platform architectures that permit no contestation. Witnessing, as Peters (2001, p. 710) argues, is not merely observation but an act situated at "the difficult juncture between presence and absence." When corporate humanitarian communication positions publics as witnesses to technological generosity rather than as witnesses to the governance exercised over displaced communities, the ethical structure of witnessing is redirected.

The relationship between humanitarian discourse and colonial technological practice has been examined across several bodies of scholarship (Stoll, 2024), but without systematic specification of the communicative mechanism through which legitimation operates. The term techno-humanitarianism was coined to describe technological solutionism applied to humanitarian governance (Morozov, 2012), and the concept was subsequently developed to examine the technologising of humanitarian space as a field of biopolitical control (Tazzioli, 2020). Both contributions name the phenomenon. Neither provides an analytical framework for distinguishing its empirically diverse forms or identifying the authority claims and subject positions each form produces. The intellectual history of digital colonialism identifies a discourse of "benevolence" as one of the core features enabling technological expansion into the Global South (Nothias, 2025, p. 386). The smartness mandate describes the widely

MCS Prior Review

accepted assumption that smart technologies should organise governance across domains, naturalising technocratic intervention as self-evidently rational (Halpern and Mitchell, 2023, pp. 1–4). Taken together, the relationship between humanitarian discourse and technocolonial practice has been described as convergence (Madianou, 2019) and benevolent obfuscation (Nothias, 2025). What remains absent is a framework specifying the mechanism of discursive enablement itself. No existing account explains how different types of corporate technology generate different forms of humanitarian authority, how that authority is communicatively constituted rather than institutionally conferred, and what consequences follow for the communities over whom that authority is exercised.

This article addresses that gap. It asks *how techno-humanitarianism functions as the communicative mechanism through which corporate technological deployment acquires humanitarian authority over crisis-affected communities, and what subject positions this mechanism produces.*

The argument has two dimensions. The first is analytical. Techno-humanitarianism is theorised as a constitutive discourse through which corporate technological governance over vulnerable communities is legitimated as care. The efficiency language and crisis rhetoric are the performative acts through which this constitution is achieved. Drawing on field theory (Bourdieu, 1986, 1993) and constitutive communication theory (Craig, 1999; Cooren, 2010), the article develops a

MCS for Review

framework for analysing how corporate actors convert operational market capital into humanitarian symbolic capital. The second dimension is empirical. Through qualitative multiple case study analysis of thirteen cases across five technologically mediated modes (platform, financial, connectivity, data and AI, and energy), the article demonstrates that the communicative features generating techno-humanitarian authority are structurally identical to the features that make accountability impossible.

The article makes two contributions. The first is empirical. A five-mode typology specifies, for each mode, the authority claim corporate actors construct and the subject position produced for crisis-affected communities, moving the study of techno-humanitarianism from diagnosis to specification. The second is theoretical. The analysis demonstrates that techno-humanitarianism operates in the register of pity (Boltanski, 1999, pp. 3–15) and is structurally incapable of generating the politics of justice, because the accountability conditions that justice requires are precisely those that techno-humanitarian authority forecloses.

MCS for Review

2. Theoretical Framework

Techno-Humanitarianism and Its Theoretical Context

The post-humanitarian framework identifies a mutation in the communicative structure through which solidarity is performed. The transformation traces a departure from solidarity-based regimes toward forms of engagement organised around individual self-expression. Post-humanitarianism traces "a move from an other-oriented morality, where doing good to others is about our common humanity" toward "a self-oriented morality, where doing good to others is about 'how I feel'" (Chouliaraki, 2013, p. 31). The resulting "instrumentalization" (p. 11) of the humanitarian field means that giving is an act of identity construction. This framework was developed to account for INGOs adopting the communicative grammar of the market, not for corporate actors assuming humanitarian operational functions.

The structural conditions enabling that assumption are specified in the market humanitarianism literature (Barnett, 2011; Hopgood, 2013; Duffield, 2016). The humanitarian emphasis on "palliation" rather than transformation means that it "deals with the world as it is and with the hope of alleviating the suffering of the moment" (Barnett, 2011, p. 37). Corporate humanitarian communication intensifies this political limit. A technology corporation deploying disaster response infrastructure addresses immediate need with exceptional efficiency while remaining insulated from the question

MCS for Review

of why that disaster produced that harm at that scale. The accountability deficit the typology identifies is not only institutional but political.

Corporate technology now performs functions that international humanitarian law assigns to states and INGOs, from shelter provision through platform networks to predictive analytics through cloud computing. The concept of techno-humanitarianism names this convergence of technological deployment and humanitarian governance (Morozov, 2012; Tazzioli, 2020). The crisis rhetoric framing these deployments activates what can be understood as a suspension of normal accountability requirements (Agamben, 1998). "Refugee crisis" and "humanitarian emergency" function as performative invocations that create temporal windows in which operational deployment proceeds faster than institutional oversight can follow. The necropolitical dimension of this process is equally significant. The "ultimate expression of sovereignty" is the power to dictate "who is able to live and who must die" (Mbembe, 2019, p. 66). This sovereign determination operates through the same crisis register that constitutes corporate technological governance as care. Who is made to live through technological inclusion and who is left outside the platform determines not only access but recognisability. Emergency technologies deployed under these conditions are rarely rolled back. The infrastructure becomes the field's institutional reality.

The Discourse-Enablement Thesis

MCS for Review

Existing accounts describe the relationship between humanitarian discourse and colonial technological practice in terms that stop short of specifying the communicative mechanism through which legitimation operates.

The technocolonialism framework identifies multiple interconnected processes within digital humanitarian technology, including the extraction of value from refugee data, the materialisation of discrimination, increasing marketisation, and the absence of meaningful "processes of accountability" (Madianou, 2019, pp. 1–2; 2025, p. 128). Humanitarian discourse is treated as one logic among several. The relationship proposed is convergence rather than discursive enablement. Convergence implies that humanitarian and technocolonial logics operate in parallel, reinforcing each other without one functioning as the condition of possibility for the other. The present article's claim is stronger. Without the humanitarian register, the technocolonial operation would be visible as such. The register does not accompany corporate technological governance. It constitutes that governance as care.

Research on migration management as technological experimentation identifies how vulnerable populations become "technological testing grounds" for systems later deployed in wider governance contexts (Molnar, 2020). The testing-ground thesis demonstrates that humanitarian settings function as laboratories for corporate technology, but it does not generalise the communicative mechanism through which that experimentation is legitimated or specify how humanitarian framing varies across

MCS for Review

technological modes. An intellectual history of digital colonialism identifies a discourse of "benevolence" enabling technological expansion into the Global South (Nothias, 2025) but does not theorise techno-humanitarianism as a discursive formation with communicative features that vary across modes. The concept of the "technology of good" advances this terrain by identifying how digital humanitarian technologies operate simultaneously as interventions and as mechanisms that naturalise technocratic power while obscuring accountability asymmetries (Madianou, 2025). This article extends that analysis in two directions. It provides the typological specification the framework lacks, demonstrating that techno-humanitarian communication takes empirically distinct forms depending on the technological infrastructure deployed. It reframes the relationship from convergence to enablement. Techno-humanitarianism does not merely converge with technocolonial practice. It functions as its primary legitimating grammar. The distinction between convergence and enablement is analytically consequential. If the relationship is convergence, then reforming humanitarian discourse leaves technocolonial practice intact. If the relationship is enablement, then the humanitarian register is not a parallel phenomenon but the condition of possibility for the authority corporate technological governance acquires. Removing or contesting the register does not merely alter how the practice is described. It removes the basis on which the practice is accepted as legitimate.

The Constitutive Mechanism and Capital Conversion

MCS for Review

The constitutive communication tradition provides the mechanism through which enablement operates. Communication, in this account, is not the transmission of pre-formed meanings but "the primary social process" through which "institutional reality" is produced (Craig, 1999, p. 126). Authority is "produced and reproduced through communicative acts" and ratified or contested by the audiences those acts address (Cooren, 2010, p. 42). The broader CCO tradition holds that organisations are ongoing communicative accomplishments (Brummans et al., 2014; Schoeneborn et al., 2019). Applied to the humanitarian field, corporate techno-humanitarian authority is not a status conferred by institutional gatekeepers. It is a communicative accomplishment sustained through repeated framing acts. When a platform company frames its host network mobilisation as emergency shelter provision, that framing is a performative act. It constitutes the technology as humanitarian and the corporation as a humanitarian authority, while placing affected communities in a specific governance position. Without the humanitarian register, the same infrastructure would be recognisable as market expansion or data extraction.

The appropriate unit of analysis is the humanitarian field. In Bourdieu's (1993) account, the field is a structured space of positions in which actors compete for capital according to rules that are themselves contested. As Couldry argues, media institutions possess a form of "meta-capital" that operates not within a single field but across the boundaries between fields, shaping how social reality is categorised and which actors

MCS Prior Review

acquire the symbolic authority to define legitimate practice (Couldry, 2003, p. 667). Communication is constitutive of the humanitarian field. Humanitarian actors acquire legitimacy through communicative acts that position them within the field's hierarchy of credibility, not prior to communication but through it. The entry of corporate technological actors introduces a problem of capital conversion. Capital accumulated in one field can be converted into capital valid in another, "but only at the cost of a more or less great effort of transformation" (Bourdieu, 1986, p. 252). The humanitarian field's dominant capital is moral and testimonial, grounded in non-profit motivation and accountability to affected communities. Corporate market capital, grounded in efficiency, scale, brand recognition, and shareholder obligation, is structurally mismatched. The discourse-enablement thesis specifies the mechanism of conversion that Bourdieu's framework leaves open. The communicative framing of technology as humanitarian is the transformation effort through which operational market capital is converted into humanitarian symbolic capital.

Communicative Authority and Relational Address

Communicative authority is defined here as the socially recognised capacity of an actor to make claims treated as credible and actionable. In humanitarian contexts, authority has been theorised as grounded in three resources, each embedded in accountability structures. The first is mandate, the right to act conferred by international

MCS for Review

humanitarian law or organisational charter (Slim, 2015). The second is testimony, the epistemic authority derived from proximate witness to suffering. The structure of witnessing "relies on the professional authority of the journalist to manage the 'visceral' truth of suffering and make it available for the spectator's judgement" (Chouliaraki, 2013, p. 140). The test of authenticity in this structure is whether emotion produces action. "The proof of the inauthentic character of the emotion is that it is not followed up with action" (Boltanski, 1999, p. 43). Corporate techno-humanitarian communication complicates this test because the action is performed by the infrastructure, not by the spectator. The third is moral disinterest, the credibility conferred by non-profit motivation (Hopgood, 2013). Corporate technological actors lack all three. They operate without humanitarian mandate or proximity testimony, and with motivations structurally entangled with corporate interest. The framework proposes that corporate techno-humanitarian communication generates authority through a fourth resource, operational reach, the demonstrated capacity to deliver outcomes at a scale and speed that conventional humanitarian actors cannot match. Operational reach is not self-evidently humanitarian. It becomes humanitarian through the communicative acts that frame deployment as a response to human suffering. Operational reach takes empirically distinct forms. Relational reach operates in platform networks. Financial reach operates in payment systems. Communicative reach operates in telecommunications

MCS for Review

infrastructure. Epistemic reach operates in data and AI systems. Energetic reach operates in decentralised energy systems.

The second construct is the relational structure of humanitarian address. Humanitarian communication classically operates through what the politics of pity framework terms a structure organised around the spectacle of suffering presented to distant spectators (Boltanski, 1999, pp. 3–19). The arrangement "separates safe spectators from vulnerable others and communicates its moral message through the staging of spectacles of suffering" (Chouliaraki, 2013, p. 27). Audiences are not witnessing crisis directly. As the foundational account of mediated witnessing puts it, "the witness (speech-act) of the witness (person) was witnessed (by an audience)" (Peters, 2001, p. 709), a chain of mediated relay in which "the sense of involvement in the events that knowledge of them provides" combines with "the sense of powerlessness that distance perpetuates" (Kyriakidou, 2015, p. 217). Media framing choices distribute audiences across affective, ecstatic, politicised, and detached modes of engagement (Kyriakidou, 2015, p. 222).

Corporate techno-humanitarian communication disrupts this structure through a double articulation, producing both a symbolic-discursive positioning and a material-territorial positioning for affected communities (Chouliaraki & Georgiou, 2022). In discursive terms, affected communities are addressed through the humanitarian register of care and beneficiary status. In material terms, they are governed through

MCS for Review

technological infrastructure that determines what they can and cannot do. The critical datafication literature specifies how this governance operates. Digital humanitarian tools reconfigure power relationships (Sandvik et al., 2014), centralise control through quantification (Jacobsen, 2015; Firoz, 2024), and obscure governance effects through competing logics of innovation and ignorance (Cheesman, 2024). Critical migration media scholarship reinforces this analysis. Media infrastructures deployed in migration governance reflect "imaginaries of technological solutionism" (Seuferling & Leurs, 2021, p. 670), reducing affected communities to administrative categories through "paper-based infrastructures, mediating emerging imaginaries of refugee governance" (p. 679) that extend institutional reach across historical lineages of containment and surveillance.

The positions produced cannot be reduced to the donor-beneficiary dyad. They vary along two dimensions. The first is agency, the degree to which the position affords capacity to act within the governance relationship. The second is address-directness, the degree to which the community is directly addressed rather than addressed through intermediaries. The subaltern's structural inability to speak within dominant epistemic frameworks (Spivak, 1988) finds a technological analogue in techno-humanitarian governance. Communities governed through platform terms, financial infrastructure, or predictive analytics occupy positions from which contestation is foreclosed by the technological mediation itself. They speak as users, data points, financial agents, or

MCS for Review

connectivity dependents, but not as rights-bearing subjects with legitimate claims on the actors governing their lives. Recent scholarship argues that humanitarian communication should shift toward "the lifeworlds of the poor and vulnerable rather than those of witnesses" (Ong, 2019, p. 2681). The subject positions techno-humanitarianism produces are positions from which the afflicted cannot speak as afflicted.

A Five-Mode Typology of Techno-Humanitarian Communication

The article proposes a typology of five analytically distinct modes (Table 1). The typology classifies modes of communicative action rather than types of organisation. A single corporate actor may operate across multiple modes. Each mode is defined by the type of technological infrastructure deployed and the form of communicative authority claim it generates. Each also specifies a relational subject position for affected communities.

Table 1. Five Modes of Techno-Humanitarian Communication

Mode	Infrastructure Type	Primary Authority Claim	Relational Subject Position
1. Platform	Digital consumer platform networks	Relational reach and social trust	Service user with contractual rights
2. Financial	Payment rails and monetary transfer systems	Financial reach and economic inclusion	Economic subject with financial agency
3. Connectivity	Telecommunications and internet infrastructure	Communicative reach and network capacity	Communicative subject reconstituted through restored infrastructure
4. Data and AI	Cloud computing and predictive analytics	Epistemic reach and knowledge production	Data subject mediated through analytics

MCS for Review

5. Energy	Decentralised energy systems	Energetic reach and infrastructural autonomy	Energy-autonomous community agent

The typology focuses on technologically mediated modes because these produce the digitally encoded subject positions that make the argument distinctive. Non-technological forms deploy material capacity but do not produce ongoing governance relationships encoded in platform architecture. The logistics mode is retained as a contextual contrast case.

MCS for Review

3. Methodology

I adopted a qualitative multiple case study design (Yin, 2018; Stake, 1995). The research question is exploratory and phenomenon-defining rather than confirmatory, calling for contextually grounded description from which theoretical categories can be developed and refined (Eisenhardt, 1989).

The unit of analysis is the communicative episode through which a corporate technological actor claims humanitarian authority and positions crisis-affected communities as subjects of that authority. The thirteen cases are cases of the discursive work through which technology deployment becomes humanitarian (Bourdieu, 1986).

Case and mode selection

I selected thirteen cases across five technologically mediated modes, with two to four cases per mode, following replication logic (Yin, 2018). The five modes are Platform, Financial, Connectivity, Data and AI, and Energy. Within each mode, I chose an anchor case and one or two secondary cases introducing variation in crisis type, organisational scale, and INGO partnership. Across modes, selection followed maximum variation logic (Patton, 2002) to ensure diversity of corporate sector, geographic scope, and institutional arrangement.

I selected the five modes on a single criterion. In each, the technology itself is the medium through which corporate authority over crisis-affected communities is

MCS for Review

communicatively constituted, simultaneously delivering the humanitarian function and encoding the subject position of its recipients. Logistics deployments and manufacturing conversions deploy material capacity, but neither produces the digitally encoded subject positions through which affected communities are governed at a distance. I reference these non-technological forms as structural contrast but exclude them from the primary analysis.

The Energy mode contains a single anchor case, reflecting the scarcity of well-documented corporate energy deployments in humanitarian contexts during the study period. I address this limitation in the discussion. The temporal scope (2012 to 2025) reflects structural heterogeneity in the dataset, with acute emergency responses generating concentrated communicative activity and financial or data partnerships generating activity distributed across years. Table 2 presents the full case selection matrix.

MCS for Review

Table 2. Case selection matrix, anchor and secondary cases by mode, crisis type, and temporal scope (2012 to 2025)

Mode	Case Role	Organisation	Initiative	Crisis Type	Period
Platform	Anchor	Airbnb / Airbnb.org	Emergency housing programme	Displacement / conflict	2012–2025
	Secondary	GoFundMe	Disaster and refugee crowdfunding	Multiple emergencies	2015–2025
	Secondary	Lyft	LyftUp disaster response	Natural disaster	2017–2025

Financial	Anchor	Mastercard	Aid Network	Displacement / aid delivery	2015–present
	Secondary	Visa	Humanitarian payments infrastructure	Displacement / conflict	2015–present
	Secondary	Western Union	Refugee remittance programme	Displacement	2016–present
Connectivity	Anchor	SpaceX	Starlink Ukraine deployment	Armed conflict	2022–2025
	Secondary	Cisco	Refugee connectivity programme	Displacement	2015–present
	Secondary	Google	Project Shield	Human rights / civil society	2013–present
Data and AI	Anchor	Palantir	UNHCR and WFP data analytics	Displacement	2016–present
	Secondary	Google	Crisis Response / FireSat	Multiple emergencies	2017–present
	Secondary	Microsoft	AI for Humanitarian Action	Multiple emergencies	2018–present
Energy	Anchor	Tesla	Powerwall emergency microgrids	Natural disaster	2017–present

Note. Each mode classifies a communicative act rather than an organisation type. The Lyft case carries reduced analytical weight due to limited documentation. Google Project Shield sits at the boundary between Connectivity and Governance. I use this boundary position analytically in the findings.*

Data collection and analysis

For each case I collected organisational communications (press releases, corporate responsibility reports, campaign microsites, partnership statements, impact assessments) and news media coverage from national and international English-language outlets during the case's active period (Craig, 1999; Cooren, 2010). I treated

MCS for Review

media coverage as a record of public reception rather than factual verification. For cases where contestation is analytically significant, I collected a third category of civil society reports from organisations such as Privacy International and Access Now. The resulting corpus comprises 134 documents across the thirteen cases. I continued collection until theoretical saturation was reached for each mode (Glaser and Strauss, 2017). The restriction to English-language sources privileges globally visible actors.

I analysed the data through a framework analysis procedure (Ritchie and Spencer, 1994). The five modes and the two cross-cutting dimensions of communicative authority and relational address served as theoretically prior categories. During the first stage of coding I added a further dimension, discourse-enablement dynamics, to trace how humanitarian framing legitimates techno-colonial practice in each mode. I coded each extract manually in structured spreadsheets along four dimensions, recording the type of authority claim (operational, epistemic, or infrastructural), the relational address (whether affected communities were positioned as beneficiaries, users, data subjects, or agents), the discursive mechanism of legitimation, and the discourse-enablement dynamic linking the humanitarian claim to its techno-colonial effect. I then charted indexed material into case summary templates and conducted cross-case mapping, comparing secondary cases against anchor cases within each mode. Where secondary cases confirmed the mode's defining characteristics, I treated this as literal replication. Where they diverged, I used the divergence to identify the conditions under which a

MCS for Review

mode operates differently. The comparison between Mastercard and Western Union, for instance, revealed that the authority claim shifts from institutional to situational when the corporate actor lacks an INGO partnership structure. For each mode I also compared organisational communications against their reception in media coverage and civil society reports (Lincoln and Guba, 1985). In the Palantir-UNHCR case, the partnership's own communications framed data analytics as "evidence-based protection," while Privacy International and Access Now contested precisely this framing.

The empirical corpus is publicly available at [DOI] via Harvard Dataverse, containing organisational communications, media coverage metadata, and civil society reports for all thirteen cases. Full-text documents are provided where copyright permits, with metadata records and original URLs for copyrighted sources.

MCS for Review

4. Findings

The framework analysis across thirteen cases and five modes produces a consistent finding. Humanitarian framing does not describe corporate technological deployments. It constitutes them as humanitarian, generating authority claims and subject positions through which corporate governance of vulnerable communities becomes legible as care. Table 2 summarises the constitutive operation, lexical register, accountability displacement mechanism, and subject position for each mode. The prose below analyses the evidence comparatively rather than mode by mode, because the analytical contribution lies in the cross-modal consistency of the mechanism rather than in the distinctiveness of individual cases.

MCS for Review

Table 2. Evidence Summary: Constitutive Operations Across Five Modes

Mode	Anchor case	Constitutive operation	Key lexical register	Accountability displacement	Subject position	Confirming secondary cases
Platform	Airbnb (Ukraine, 2022)	Announcement transforms commercial accommodation into emergency shelter; IOM carries legal accountability while Airbnb retains governance	"Dignity," "home not shelter," scale metrics as humanitarian impact	Speed of deployment forecloses institutional embedding; corporate terms of service replace rights frameworks	Service user governed by platform terms	GoFundMe: supplicant subject; Palestinian campaigns rejected over terminology (01b-CS-001)
Financial	Mastercard Aid Network (2015–2023)	CEO address to UN Security Council repositions payment processing as "life-saving assistance at the last mile"	"Financial inclusion," "dignity" through consumer choice, "whole of our businesses into service"	Affective register of consumer dignity forecloses entitlement mechanisms; cards blocked with no appeals process	Economic subject with nominal financial agency	Visa B-READY (02b-OC-002); Western Union: 10.8% fees legitimated as "Economic First Responders" (02c-OC-003)
Connectivity	SpaceX Starlink (Ukraine, 2022)	Eleven-word tweet substitutes	"Connectivity as lifeline," gift	Personal authority	Connectivity dependent;	Cisco: bandwidth in

		for bilateral agreement; same personal authority activates and deactivates wartime infrastructure	vocabulary masking sovereign infrastructure control	generating humanitarian legitimacy is structurally incompatible with oversight mechanisms	communities and states constituted through corporate infrastructure	DRC governed by automated corporate architecture (03b-OC-003)
Data and AI	Palantir–WFP (2019–2025)	"Moral imperative" language naturalises algorithmic governance over 90 million beneficiaries as care	"Data-driven care," "transform global humanitarian delivery," efficiency as moral necessity	Humanitarian register absorbs contestation; partnership expanded despite open letters, Amnesty reports, ICE controversy	Data subject who cannot inspect, challenge, or withdraw from analytical systems without withdrawing from aid	Google SOS Alerts (04b-OC-002); Microsoft AI for Humanitarian Action (04c-OC-001)
Energy	Tesla (Puerto Rico, 2017)	Twitter exchange with Governor constitutes territory as "flagship project" for technology demonstration	"Energy resilience," "solar," green capitalism vocabulary	Autonomy contingent on absent corporate maintenance; non-functional hardware reveals dependency	Energy-autonomous agent (most autonomy-granting, but structurally contingent)	No secondary case; single-case limitation acknowledged

The constitutive operation and capital conversion

Each mode performs the same foundational operation through different communicative acts. A corporate technological capacity is announced, framed, or partnered into existence as humanitarian through the register in which it is communicated. The Airbnb announcement that it would "offer free, short-term housing to up to 100,000 refugees" (case reference 01a-OC-002) did not report a humanitarian capacity that already existed. It constituted commercial accommodation infrastructure as emergency shelter through the act of announcement itself. The joint IOM statement four days later positioned the response as addressing "one of the largest humanitarian crises of our lifetime" (01a-OC-003). The partnership structure made the constitutive logic visible. IOM carried the legal accountability obligations that humanitarian law requires.

MCS for Review

Airbnb retained governance authority. Without the humanitarian register, this arrangement would be recognisable as outsourcing, not humanitarian action.

The financial mode performed the same operation at the highest available institutional level. The 2023 Mastercard CEO address to the UN Security Council repositioned payment processing through the vocabulary of "life-saving assistance at the last mile" (02a-OC-003). The formulation "putting the whole of our businesses into service" dissolved the boundary between commercial operations and humanitarian acts. This is the capital conversion the theoretical framework predicts (Bourdieu, 1986), achieved through communicative constitution (Craig, 1999; Cooren, 2010). Trade coverage confirmed the dual function. A Mastercard Director stated that the Aid Network was about "seeding the market" (02a-MC-003). The connectivity and data modes replicated this logic at different scales. Musk's eleven-word tweet constituting the Starlink deployment (03a-OC-001) substituted a social media message for a bilateral agreement. The WFP announcement framing the Palantir partnership as an effort to "transform global humanitarian delivery" (04a-OC-001) naturalised algorithmic governance over 90 million beneficiaries as care. In each case, the communicative act did not accompany a pre-existing humanitarian function. It produced the humanitarian legibility of an otherwise commercial or surveillance operation.

Subject positions and foreclosed accountability

MCS Prior Review

The constitutive operation produces structurally specific subject positions for affected communities. These positions vary across modes but share a common feature. They foreclose accountability by substituting corporate governance for rights-based frameworks. Platform-mode subjects were required to create accounts and accept corporate terms of service (01a-OC-006). They were constituted not as refugees with Convention rights but as service users governed by commercial governance. Financial-mode subjects were constituted as empowered consumers through the "dignity" framing, yet CGAP/World Bank research documented that Mastercard-backed chip cards in Jordan and Lebanon were blocked for up to two months with no appeals mechanism (02a-MC-004). The affective register of consumer dignity foreclosed the entitlement mechanisms that a rights framework would require.

The data and AI mode carried this foreclosure to its limit. The subject position it produced, the data subject, could not inspect, challenge, or withdraw from the analytical systems governing their aid without withdrawing from the aid itself. Sixty-five civil society organisations identified de-anonymisation risk and algorithmic bias, along with a broader accountability vacuum (04a-CS-002). The Palantir-WFP partnership expanded despite the open letter and the Amnesty reports, as well as the ICE controversy (04a-MC-004). The humanitarian register structurally absorbed contestation by constituting critique as opposition to humanitarian efficiency. The energy mode complicated the pattern productively. Tesla's Puerto Rico microgrid produced the most

MCS for Review

autonomy-granting subject position in the typology. Yet the HuffPost "solar graveyard" investigation on Vieques documented the collapse of this position when corporate maintenance infrastructure was absent (05a-MC-003). Even the strongest form of technological autonomy in the corpus remained structurally contingent on corporate infrastructure.

The connectivity mode demonstrated the accountability paradox at its sharpest. The same personal authority that activated Starlink as a humanitarian gesture deactivated it near Crimea as a geopolitical calculation (03a-CS-001). SpaceX demanded Pentagon funding to continue service (03a-OC-003). Ukrainian officials described Starlink as the "blood of [the] entire communication infrastructure" (03a-MC-002). The humanitarian framing of the initial activation had constituted this sovereign dependency as a gift.

Cross-cutting findings

Four analytical findings emerge across the five modes.

First, two distinct forms of unaccountable authority operate. Situational authority (platform, connectivity) is generated by crisis-responsive acts that outpace accountability formation. Institutional authority (financial, data, energy) accumulates through technical partnerships insulated from affected communities. Both produce governance without accountability, but through different temporal structures.

MCS for Review

Second, an inverse relationship holds between technical complexity and capacity for self-representation. The more technically complex the mode, the more thoroughly communities are constituted through Northern corporate infrastructure and the less capacity they retain for self-representation within the governance relationship. A service user retains navigational agency. A data subject retains none. Energy is the partial exception, because autonomy is real where hardware functions but collapses into dependency when it does not.

Third, all five modes replicate the directional asymmetry that the technocolonialism thesis identifies (Madianou, 2019). Technologies, governance frameworks, and data flows move from North to South. Authority and capital move from South to North. No case in the corpus reverses this directionality.

Fourth, the humanitarian register performs the same discursive operation across all five modes. It transforms corporate technological governance into morally necessary activity. The field-specific vocabulary varies, from "dignity" and "home" in platform mode to "data-driven care" in data mode. The operation is constant. Each vocabulary item constitutes a corporate governance relationship as humanitarian care and forecloses the accountability frameworks that would otherwise apply. The resulting subject positions prevent affected communities from contesting the governance terms. The relationship between humanitarian framing and technocolonial practice is not convergence (Madianou, 2019). It is discursive enablement. The humanitarian register

MCS Prior Review

is the constitutive mechanism through which corporate technological governance of vulnerable communities is legitimated.

MCS for Review

5. Discussion

This article asked how techno-humanitarianism functions as the communicative mechanism through which corporate technological deployment acquires humanitarian authority over crisis-affected communities. The findings suggest that techno-humanitarianism operates as the communicative grammar of technocolonialism. It is the constitutive discourse through which corporate governance of crisis-affected communities is legitimated as care. The humanitarian register supplies the vocabulary through which commercial deployment is recognised as humanitarian response and through which affected communities are addressed as beneficiaries rather than as governed subjects.

Existing accounts identified this phenomenon as convergence (Madianou, 2019, 2025), benevolent obfuscation (Nothias, 2025), or techno-solutionism (Morozov, 2012; Tazzioli, 2020). The findings suggest these are dimensions of one constitutive mechanism. Two propositions and a structural condition follow.

The grammar of inverse empowerment

Across all five modes, techno-humanitarian communication uses the language of empowerment, inclusion, access, and autonomy to constitute asymmetric dependency. The convergence thesis (Madianou, 2019) and the concept of the technology of good (Madianou, 2025) identify this asymmetry but not the communicative structure

MCS for Review

producing it. The grammar of inverse empowerment identifies a consistent pattern in which the humanitarian register constitutes incorporation into centralised corporate systems as connection to global infrastructure. The same structure operates across platform, connectivity, energy, and data modes, but the financial mode illustrates it most precisely. The "dignity" framing constitutes enrolment in proprietary payment infrastructure as consumer empowerment. Recipients are addressed as autonomous economic agents exercising choice. The infrastructure they are enrolled in can disconnect them without recourse or appeal.

The distinction Boltanski (1999) draws between the politics of pity and the politics of justice explains what makes this constitutive move possible. The register of pity positions recipients as objects of care rather than agents of self-determination. Within pity's grammar, to be empowered is to be connected on terms set entirely by the empowering actor. The "dignity" of consumer choice is precisely this form of connection. The concept of recognisability Butler (2009) develops extends the analysis to the infrastructure itself. What counts as a legitimate subject position is determined not by the community but by the technological architecture that frames it. The financial subject is recognisable as empowered only within the payment system's own terms. The position Mignolo (2011) advances reveals the deeper logic. Visibility within the Western gaze operates as a trap because it forecloses alternative forms of recognition. Affected communities are made visible as empowered, which forecloses the recognition

MCS for Review

that what has occurred is incorporation into governance architectures they cannot contest.

The humanitarian frontier as incubation space

The findings suggest that humanitarian crisis functions not as an exceptional condition activating emergency corporate deployment but as a permanent condition of possibility for technological governance. The conditions Agamben (1998) identifies as constitutive of the state of exception are visible across all five modes. Crisis rhetoric suspends the regulatory and participatory constraints that would apply in non-crisis settings. The humanitarian label shields the technology from criticism during the deployment phase. By the time the technology is refined, the humanitarian framing has already normalised it.

This analysis proposes that the relationship between humanitarianism and technological development is one of incubation rather than application. The Global South functions as a laboratory for technologies that would face regulatory constraint or social contestation if deployed first in the Global North. The analysis Molnar (2020) provides demonstrates the return of frontier technologies to domestic settings through the imperial boomerang. The present findings extend that argument by identifying the economic function of the humanitarian frontier. Surveillance tools, biometric systems, and automated decision-making are tested on communities with the least institutional

MCS for Review

capacity to refuse consent. The suffering of crisis-affected communities is converted into a development phase for governance products. The problem Halpern and Mitchell (2023) diagnose, that the smartness mandate naturalises technological intervention as self-evidently beneficial, receives its sharpest confirmation in the humanitarian field. Crisis generates the temporal urgency that suspends deliberative constraints, and the humanitarian register generates the moral authority that insulates the deployment from critique.

The constitutive accountability paradox

The humanitarian accountability literature treats the deficit in corporate humanitarian communication as a correctable gap (Slim, 2015; Barnett, 2011). The assumption is that regulation or institutional reform could in principle address it. The findings require a different interpretation. Across all five modes, the conditions that generate corporate humanitarian authority are structurally incompatible with the conditions that would enable accountability. Speed of deployment precludes the consultation that accountability requires. Operational scale precludes the participatory processes through which affected communities would gain standing to contest governance terms. Applied to the humanitarian field, the logic of capital conversion (Bourdieu, 1986) explains why. Corporate actors enter the humanitarian field by exceeding its operational capacity. The communicative acts that frame deployment as

MCS for Review

humanitarian response generate authority precisely because they bypass the institutionally embedded processes through which traditional humanitarian authority is held accountable. Restoring accountability would eliminate the speed and scale that generate the authority claim.

The register of pity Boltanski (1999) theorises frames the relationship between the corporate actor and the affected community as one of care rather than governance. To demand accountability for care is to violate the moral grammar of the relationship. The register of justice would recognise the relationship as governance and subject it to democratic scrutiny. The register of pity forecloses that recognition. The analytical vocabulary Chouliaraki and Georgiou (2022) introduce makes visible how this operates at two levels simultaneously. The symbolic-discursive positioning of affected communities as beneficiaries of care enables their material-territorial positioning as subjects of unaccountable governance. The sequential relationship means that contesting the material governance requires first contesting the discursive framing as care.

Implications and future directions

The two propositions and the structural condition generate implications that extend beyond the evidence of any single mode. The grammar of inverse empowerment reconceptualises humanitarian address by showing that the subject positions the typology identifies are inversions in which empowering language constitutes dependent

MCS for Review

positioning. The incubation proposition extends the constitutive tradition (Craig, 1999; Cooren, 2010). It shows that communicative acts in the humanitarian field produce not only institutional reality but also the regulatory conditions under which technological governance operates without constraint. The constitutive accountability paradox advances field theory by showing that capital conversion in the humanitarian field requires the absence of accountability as a structural precondition.

For humanitarian governance, the central implication is that the accountability deficit cannot be corrected by reform because it is constitutive of the system it sustains. INGOs that compete with corporate actors on operational terms face the structural disadvantage the market humanitarianism literature anticipated (Barnett, 2011; Hopgood, 2013). The strategic alternative is to reframe the terms on which humanitarian authority is evaluated, foregrounding accountability to affected communities and rights-based programme design as criteria that corporate actors structurally cannot replicate.

Four directions for future research follow. The most pressing direction concerns reception by affected communities. The grammar of inverse empowerment is derived from Northern institutional and media sources, and whether it corresponds to how governed communities understand their positioning is an open question. The shift Ong (2019) calls for, from the lifeworlds of witnesses to those of vulnerable communities, specifies the object of study. The decolonial epistemology Mignolo (2011) articulates specifies the conditions under which that study should proceed, because reception

MCS for Review

research risks reproducing the extractive dynamic it seeks to examine if communities' accounts are tested against Northern analytical frameworks rather than accessed through their own epistemic categories. A second direction concerns the longitudinal dynamics of the incubation cycle, examining whether technologies tested in humanitarian contexts migrate to domestic governance on predictable timelines. A third direction would test whether techno-humanitarian communication produces politicised witnessing or spectacle. The account of witnessing as communicative duty Peters (2001) establishes and the reception typology Kyriakidou (2015) proposes provide frameworks for this assessment. A fourth direction would examine whether the communities most in need of protection are systematically required to surrender the most privacy in exchange for assistance.

6. Conclusion

This article has argued that techno-humanitarianism functions as the legitimating discourse for techno-colonial practice. The analysis demonstrates that humanitarian framing constitutes the communicative apparatus through which corporate technological deployment acquires unaccountable authority over crisis-affected communities across five technologically mediated modes.

The analysis advances two propositions and identifies one structural condition beyond the discourse-enablement thesis itself. The grammar of inverse empowerment

MCS for Review

identifies how the humanitarian register produces dependency as empowerment, constituting incorporation as access. The incubation proposition identifies how the humanitarian frontier functions as a testing ground for technologies that would face constraint if deployed first in the Global North. The constitutive accountability paradox identifies how the conditions generating corporate humanitarian authority are structurally incompatible with the conditions enabling accountability, and how the humanitarian register converts that incompatibility from a defect into a credential.

The normative horizon of this analysis returns to the question with which the article opened. If the humanitarian register is itself the mechanism through which corporate technological governance is produced as care, then efforts to reform humanitarian communication from within that register cannot address the structural problem the analysis identifies. The question is not how to make techno-humanitarian communication more accountable. The question is whether humanitarian communication, as it is currently constituted, can function as anything other than the legitimating grammar of unaccountable governance. Answering that question requires asking who is posing it, and from where.

MCS for Review

References

Agamben, G. (1998). *Homo sacer: Sovereign power and bare life* (D. Heller-Roazen, Trans.). Stanford University Press.

Barnett, M. (2011). *Empire of humanity: A history of humanitarianism*. Cornell University Press.

Boltanski, L. (1999). *Distant suffering: Morality, media and politics*. Cambridge University Press.

Bourdieu, P. (1993). *The field of cultural production*. Columbia University Press.

Bourdieu, P. (1986). The forms of capital. In J. G. Richardson (ed), *Handbook of theory and research for the sociology of education* (pp. 241–258). Greenwood Press.

Brummans, B. H. J. M., Cooren, F., Robichaud, D., and Taylor, J. R. (2014). Approaches to the communicative constitution of organizations. In L. L. Putnam and D. K. Mumby (eds), *The SAGE handbook of organizational communication* (3rd ed., pp. 173–194). Sage.

Butler, J. (2009). *Frames of war: When is life grievable?* Verso.

Cheesman, M. (2024). Conjuring a blockchain pilot: Ignorance and innovation in humanitarian aid. *Geopolitics*. Advance online publication. https://doi.org/10.1080/14650045.2024.2389284

Chouliaraki, L., and Georgiou, M. (2022). *The digital border: Migration, technology, power*. NYU Press.

MCS for Review

Chouliaraki, L. (2013). *The ironic spectator: Solidarity in the age of post-humanitarianism*. Polity Press.

Cooren, F. (2010). *Action and agency in dialogue*. John Benjamins.

Couldry, N. (2003). Media meta-capital: Extending the range of Bourdieu's field theory. *Theory and Society*, 32(5/6), 653–677. https://doi.org/10.1023/B:RYSO.0000004915.37826.5d

Craig, R. T. (1999). Communication theory as a field. *Communication Theory*, 9(2), 119–161. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1468-2885.1999.tb00355.x

Eisenhardt, K. M. (1989). Building theories from case study research. *Academy of Management Review*, 14(4), 532–550. https://doi.org/10.5465/amr.1989.4308385

Firoz, M. (2024). Quantifying vulnerability: Humanitarian datafication and the neophilia of integrated power. *Cultural Anthropology*, 39(3), 348–373. https://doi.org/10.14506/ca39.3.02

Glaser, B., and Strauss, A. (2017). *Discovery of grounded theory: Strategies for qualitative research*. Routledge.

Halpern, O., and Mitchell, R. (2023). *The smartness mandate*. MIT Press.

Hopgood, S. (2013). *The endtimes of human rights*. Cornell University Press.

Jacobsen, K. L. (2015). *The politics of humanitarian technology: Good intentions, unintended consequences and insecurity*. Routledge.

MCS for Review

Kyriakidou, M. (2015). Media witnessing: Exploring the audience of distant suffering. *Media, Culture and Society*, 37(2), 215–231. https://doi.org/10.1177/0163443714557981

Lincoln, Y. S., and Guba, E. G. (1985). *Naturalistic inquiry*. Sage.

Madianou, M. (2019). Technocolonialism: Digital innovation and data practices in the humanitarian response to refugee crises. *Social Media + Society*, 5(3), 1–13. https://doi.org/10.1177/2056305119863146

Madianou, M. (2025). *Technocolonialism: When technology for good is harmful*. Polity Press.

Mbembe, A. (2019). *Necropolitics*. Duke University Press.

Mignolo, W. D. (2011). *The darker side of Western modernity: Global futures, decolonial options*. Duke University Press.

Molnar, P. (2020). *Technological testing grounds: Migration management experiments and reflections from the ground up*. EDRi and the Refugee Law Lab. https://edri.org/our-work/technological-testing-grounds/

Morozov, E. (2012, August 2). The naked and the TED. *The New Republic*. https://newrepublic.com/article/105703/the-naked-and-the-ted-khanna

Nothias, T. (2025). An intellectual history of digital colonialism. *Journal of Communication*, 75(1), jqaf003. https://doi.org/10.1093/joc/jqaf003

MCS for Review

Ong, J. C. (2019). Toward an ordinary ethics of mediated humanitarian connectivity. *International Journal of Communication*, 13, 2680–2697.

Patton, M. Q. (2002). *Qualitative research and evaluation methods* (3rd ed.). Sage.

Peters, J. D. (2001). Witnessing. *Media, Culture and Society*, 23(6), 707–723. https://doi.org/10.1177/016344301023006002

Ritchie, J., and Spencer, L. (1994). Qualitative data analysis for applied policy research. In A. Bryman and R. G. Burgess (eds), *Analysing qualitative data* (pp. 173–194). Routledge.

Sandvik, K. B., Jumbert, M. G., Karlsrud, J., and Kaufmann, M. (2014). Humanitarian technology: A critical research agenda. *International Review of the Red Cross*, 96(893), 219–242. https://doi.org/10.1017/S1816383114000344

Schoeneborn, D., Kuhn, T. R., and Kärreman, D. (2019). The communicative constitution of organization, organizing, and organizationality. *Organization Studies*, 40(4), 475–496. https://doi.org/10.1177/0170840618782284

Seuferling, P., and Leurs, K. (2021). Histories of humanitarian technophilia: How imaginaries of media technologies have shaped migration infrastructures. *Mobilities*, 16(5), 670–687. https://doi.org/10.1080/17450101.2021.1960186

Slim, H. (2015). *Humanitarian ethics: A guide to the morality of aid in war and disaster*. Oxford University Press.

MCS for Review

Spivak, G. C. (1988). Can the subaltern speak? In C. Nelson and L. Grossberg (eds), *Marxism and the interpretation of culture* (pp. 271–313). University of Illinois Press.

Stake, R. E. (1995). *The art of case study research*. Sage.

Stoll, P. (2024). Lost in digital translation? The humanitarian principles in the digital age. *International Review of the Red Cross*, 106(925), 311–347. https://doi.org/10.1017/S1816383124000328

Tazzioli, M. (2020). *The making of migration: The biopolitics of mobility at Europe's borders*. Sage.

Yin, R. K. (2018). *Case study research and applications: Design and methods* (6th ed.). Sage.

MCS for Review